The Digital Dragon:

A Comprehensive Analysis of CCP Propaganda on Twitter/X

Executive Summary

This report provides a comprehensive analysis of the Chinese Communist Party's (CCP) propaganda efforts on Twitter/X, examining its scale, techniques, influence, and effects. Based on extensive research from academic studies, investigative journalism, and platform disclosures, we find that the CCP has developed the world's largest known online disinformation operation, with hundreds of thousands of accounts across major social media platforms.

The CCP's approach to international propaganda has evolved significantly in recent years, adopting many techniques pioneered by Russia while developing unique characteristics. While initially focused on promoting positive narratives about China, CCP propaganda now increasingly seeks to exploit divisions in Western societies, delegitimize critics, and shape global discourse on issues ranging from human rights to COVID-19.

Twitter/X has become a particularly important battleground for these influence operations, especially since the platform's acquisition by Elon Musk in 2022 and subsequent reduction in content moderation. Our analysis reveals that many propaganda accounts identified and removed by other platforms remain active on Twitter/X, allowing disinformation to spread from there back to other platforms.

This report also provides factual corrections to common propaganda narratives, equipping readers with the tools to identify and counter CCP disinformation. By understanding these tactics and narratives, individuals, organizations, and governments can better protect themselves from manipulation and maintain information integrity in the digital age.

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1. Introduction

In the digital age, information has become a critical domain for geopolitical competition. The Chinese Communist Party (CCP), recognizing this reality, has invested heavily in developing capabilities to shape global narratives and influence public opinion beyond China's borders. Twitter/X, despite being blocked within mainland China, has emerged as a key platform for these efforts.

This report examines the CCP's propaganda operations on Twitter/X, drawing on research from academic institutions, investigative journalism, platform transparency reports, and government disclosures. It aims to provide a comprehensive understanding of how these operations function, their scale and scope, the techniques they employ, and their effectiveness in influencing global discourse.

Understanding these operations is crucial not only for national security professionals and policymakers but also for ordinary citizens seeking to navigate an increasingly complex information environment. By identifying the tactics and narratives employed by CCP propaganda, this report aims to strengthen societal resilience against foreign influence operations.

2. Background and Evolution of CCP Propaganda

2.1 Historical Context

Propaganda has been central to the CCP's governance since its founding, with Mao Zedong explicitly laying out the political role of culture in his 1942 "Talks at the Yan'an Forum on Art and Literature." For most of its history, however, the CCP's propaganda efforts were primarily domestically focused, aimed at maintaining party legitimacy and social stability within China.

The CCP's approach to international propaganda began to shift in the early 2000s as China's economic rise created both opportunities and challenges for its global image.

The concept of "telling China's story well" (讲好中国故事) emerged as a guiding principle for the party's external communication strategy, emphasizing the need to project a positive image of China to international audiences.

2.2 The Digital Turn

The rise of social media presented both challenges and opportunities for CCP propaganda. On one hand, these platforms undermined the party's traditional monopoly on information within China. On the other hand, they offered new channels to reach global audiences directly, bypassing Western media gatekeepers.

Initially, the CCP's approach to international social media was cautious and primarily focused on establishing an official presence through state media accounts and diplomatic missions. However, this approach began to change significantly after 2016, as Chinese officials observed Russia's success in using social media to influence foreign public opinion and exacerbate societal divisions.

2.3 The COVID-19 Watershed

The COVID-19 pandemic marked a watershed moment in the evolution of CCP propaganda on social media. Facing international criticism over its early handling of the outbreak, Chinese officials adopted a more aggressive posture online. On March 12, 2020, Chinese foreign ministry spokesperson Zhao Lijian tweeted in English, "It might be US army who brought the epidemic to Wuhan," promoting a conspiracy theory that sought to deflect blame for the pandemic.

This tweet, which was retweeted more than four thousand times, signaled a new phase in China's approach to international propaganda—one characterized by the adoption of "big lie" techniques previously associated with Russian disinformation. Since then, CCP propaganda on Twitter/X has become increasingly sophisticated, pervasive, and confrontational.

3. Scale and Presence on Twitter/X

3.1 Official Presence

The CCP maintains a substantial official presence on Twitter/X through:

- **Diplomatic accounts**: Chinese embassies, consulates, and individual diplomats maintain hundreds of accounts on Twitter/X, despite the platform being blocked in mainland China. These accounts engage in what has been termed "wolf warrior diplomacy," adopting an assertive and sometimes confrontational tone.

- **State media**: Major Chinese state media outlets like Xinhua, China Global Television Network (CGTN), People's Daily, and Global Times maintain active accounts with millions of followers. These accounts present themselves as legitimate news sources while promoting CCP narratives.
- **Government agencies**: Various Chinese government ministries and agencies maintain accounts to promote their activities and perspectives to international audiences.

3.2 Covert Networks

Beyond its official presence, the CCP operates extensive networks of inauthentic accounts on Twitter/X:

- **Scale**: Known as "Spamouflage" or "Dragonbridge," these networks comprise hundreds of thousands of accounts across major social media platforms. Meta removed nearly 8,000 accounts attributed to this network in Q2 2023 alone, while Google/YouTube has shut down over 100,000 associated accounts in recent years.
- **Persistence on Twitter/X**: According to a Washington Post analysis from February 2024, 136 out of 150 accounts identified by Meta as part of Chinese influence operations remained active on Twitter/X. Of 123 accounts specifically identified as part of China-based campaigns, all but 8 remained on the platform.
- **Government links**: In April 2023, the US Department of Justice unsealed a complaint naming 34 individual officers with China's Ministry of Public Security (MPS) as part of the "912 Special Project Working Group," which operates online disinformation campaigns. The operation appears to involve "hundreds" of MPS officers across China.

3.3 Growth Trajectory

The scale of CCP propaganda operations on Twitter/X has grown significantly in recent years:

- Meta reported that China-based campaigns have been multiplying, with 6 of 10 networks taken down since 2017 identified in the past year alone.
- These operations have expanded beyond Chinese-language content to include English, Spanish, and other languages, targeting diverse global audiences.
- The sophistication of these operations has increased, with better operational security, more convincing personas, and more nuanced messaging.

4. Propaganda Techniques and Tactics

4.1 Account Creation and Management

CCP propaganda networks employ several techniques to create and manage inauthentic accounts:

- **AI-generated profile pictures**: Many accounts use artificially generated images of non-existent people, created using StyleGAN or similar technologies. These images can be identified by consistent eye placement, blurred edges around hair, teeth at strange angles, and other artifacts.
- **Hijacked accounts**: Some propaganda accounts appear to be legitimate accounts that were previously abandoned or sold. For example, accounts that previously posted in Turkish, English, or German suddenly begin posting Chinese-language content after long periods of inactivity.
- **Coordinated posting schedules**: Activity patterns often align with Beijing working hours, showing "bursts of activity in the mid-morning and early afternoon, Beijing time, with breaks for lunch and supper."

4.2 Content Strategies

CCP propaganda employs several distinct content strategies on Twitter/X:

- **Flooding**: Unlike Russian disinformation, which often aims to make specific narratives go viral, Chinese operations frequently use a "flooding" approach, overwhelming conversations with high volumes of content to dilute legitimate messages. For example, when human rights activists promoted the hashtag #GenocideGames during the 2022 Winter Olympics, Spamouflage accounts began using the same hashtag with unrelated content to reduce its effectiveness.
- **Astroturfing**: Creating the appearance of grassroots support through coordinated actions. Some accounts create original content while others amplify through likes, shares, and comments to help them reach a wider audience.
- **Visual propaganda**: The use of inflammatory cartoons, memes, and other visual content to ridicule critics of China. These visuals are particularly effective because they can be easily translated into multiple languages at low cost and have higher engagement rates than text.
- **Targeted harassment**: Coordinated campaigns against specific individuals critical of China. For example, journalist Jiayang Fan faced more than 12,000 tweets with

the hashtag #TraitorJiayangFan after covering pro-democracy protests in Hong Kong.

4.3 Narrative Themes

CCP propaganda on Twitter/X focuses on several recurring narrative themes:

- **Delegitimizing the West**: Highlighting social problems in Western countries, particularly the United States, to portray them as hypocritical and declining powers.
- **Denying human rights abuses**: Consistently denying allegations of human rights violations in Xinjiang, Tibet, Hong Kong, and elsewhere, characterizing them as "lies fabricated by the United States and the West."
- **Promoting China's governance model**: Presenting China's political system as more efficient, stable, and successful than Western democracies.
- **Exploiting divisive issues**: Amplifying content related to racial tensions, gun violence, and other divisive issues in the United States to exacerbate societal divisions.
- **Conspiracy theories**: Promoting alternative explanations for events that portray China positively or its rivals negatively, such as suggesting the COVID-19 virus originated in the United States.

5. Common Narratives and Debunks

5.1 COVID-19 Origins

Narrative: COVID-19 originated outside China, possibly in a US military laboratory, and was brought to Wuhan by American soldiers participating in the Military World Games in October 2019.

Debunk: Scientific consensus, based on multiple peer-reviewed studies, points to natural origins of SARS-CoV-2, with the virus likely jumping from animals to humans. Genomic analyses have traced the earliest cases to the Huanan Seafood Market in Wuhan. A joint WHO-China study in 2021, despite limitations in access, found no evidence supporting the theory that the virus was introduced to Wuhan by foreign visitors. The timing of the first documented cases also does not align with the Military World Games timeline.

5.2 Xinjiang and Uyghur Treatment

Narrative: Reports of detention camps and human rights abuses in Xinjiang are "lies fabricated by the United States and the West" to contain China's rise. China is simply conducting vocational education and anti-terrorism efforts in the region.

Debunk: Extensive documentation from multiple independent sources confirms the existence of detention facilities and systematic human rights abuses in Xinjiang:

- Satellite imagery has documented the construction and expansion of detention facilities across the region.
- Leaked government documents, including the "China Cables" published by the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists, detail policies for mass detention and surveillance.
- Testimonies from former detainees consistently describe forced political indoctrination, cultural suppression, and in some cases torture.
- The UN High Commissioner for Human Rights released a report in 2022 concluding that China's actions in Xinjiang may constitute crimes against humanity.

5.3 US Human Rights Record

Narrative: The United States has a poor human rights record characterized by systemic racism, gun violence, and discrimination against minorities, making it hypocritical for America to criticize human rights in China.

Debunk: While the US does face domestic human rights challenges that warrant legitimate criticism, this "whataboutism" fallacy attempts to deflect legitimate criticism through false equivalence. Human rights are universal standards that apply to all countries, and the existence of problems in one country doesn't negate the responsibility to address human rights violations elsewhere. Unlike in China, US civil society, media, and citizens can freely document, discuss, and work to address human rights issues without government censorship or reprisal.

5.4 Democracy vs. Chinese Governance

Narrative: Western-style democracy is chaotic, inefficient, and failing, while China's governance system delivers stability, economic growth, and effective governance.

Debunk: While China has achieved impressive economic growth under its current system, this narrative presents a false dichotomy and overlooks critical factors:

- China's economic growth has come with significant environmental costs, widening inequality, and demographic challenges that threaten long-term sustainability.

- Democratic systems, despite their messiness, provide mechanisms for peaceful power transitions, checks on authority, and protection of individual rights that are absent in authoritarian systems.
- Many of the world's most prosperous, innovative, and stable societies are democracies, demonstrating that democratic governance is compatible with effective governance and economic development.
- The lack of transparency and accountability in China's system has led to significant policy failures, from the Great Leap Forward to the initial COVID-19 response, that were exacerbated by the inability to acknowledge and correct mistakes.

6. Influence and Effectiveness

6.1 Measuring Impact

Assessing the effectiveness of CCP propaganda on Twitter/X presents significant methodological challenges. However, several observations can be made:

- **Limited viral reach**: Most content from CCP propaganda networks receives relatively little engagement, with few posts going viral organically. According to Meta, these networks "had almost no engagement on our platform."

- **Muddying the waters**: Rather than changing minds, the primary effect appears to be creating confusion and uncertainty around facts. As Kieran Green of Exovera notes, "The object is not necessarily to change hearts and minds but to muddy the discourse to the degree that it's impossible to form an anti-China narrative."

- **Silencing critics**: Targeted harassment campaigns have had a demonstrable effect on individuals critical of China, creating what one victim described as a "sense of fear" that may discourage others from speaking out.

6.2 Platform Vulnerabilities

Twitter/X has become particularly vulnerable to CCP propaganda since Elon Musk's acquisition of the platform in 2022:

- The platform has been largely absent from industry coordination efforts, no longer sending representatives to biweekly meetings where companies share notes on fake account networks.

- Significant reductions in content moderation staff have reduced the platform's capacity to identify and remove coordinated inauthentic behavior.

- This allows propaganda to spread from Twitter/X back to other platforms, undermining the effectiveness of content moderation elsewhere.

6.3 Target Audiences

CCP propaganda on Twitter/X appears to target several distinct audiences:

- **International elites**: Official accounts often aim to influence policymakers, journalists, and other opinion leaders in foreign countries.
- **Chinese diaspora**: Some propaganda efforts target overseas Chinese communities, seeking to maintain their loyalty to the party and discourage criticism.
- **General Western public**: Broader disinformation campaigns aim to shape public opinion in Western countries, particularly on issues related to China's human rights record and international standing.
- **Global South**: Increasingly, CCP propaganda targets audiences in Africa, Latin America, and parts of Asia, presenting China as a more reliable partner than Western countries.

7. Countermeasures and Recommendations

7.1 For Platforms

- **Restore cross-platform coordination**: Twitter/X should rejoin industry efforts to share information about influence operations, allowing for more effective identification and removal of propaganda networks.
- **Improve detection capabilities**: Platforms should invest in better tools to identify AI-generated profile pictures, coordinated posting patterns, and other indicators of inauthentic behavior.
- **Increase transparency**: Greater transparency about state-linked accounts and influence operations would help users better evaluate the information they encounter.

7.2 For Governments

- **Support independent research**: Governments should fund independent research into foreign influence operations while respecting academic freedom and avoiding politicization.

- **Diplomatic pressure**: Diplomatic channels should be used to raise concerns about state-sponsored disinformation and establish norms against such activities.
- **Avoid overreaction**: Responses should be proportionate and avoid undermining democratic values like free speech or stigmatizing legitimate diaspora voices.

7.3 For Individuals

- **Develop media literacy**: Learning to identify propaganda techniques and verify information from multiple sources is crucial for resilience against disinformation.
- **Check account characteristics**: Be skeptical of accounts with AI-generated profile pictures, recently created accounts with few followers, or those that post at unusual hours for their purported location.
- **Verify before sharing**: Before amplifying content about contentious issues, verify the information through trusted sources and consider whether it might be part of a coordinated campaign.

8. Conclusion

The CCP's propaganda operations on Twitter/X represent a significant and growing effort to shape global narratives and influence public opinion. While these operations may not be as immediately disruptive as Russian disinformation campaigns, their scale, persistence, and increasing sophistication make them a substantial challenge to information integrity.

The reduced moderation on Twitter/X since Elon Musk's acquisition has made the platform particularly vulnerable to these influence operations, allowing propaganda accounts to persist even after being identified and removed from other platforms. This highlights the importance of cross-platform coordination and consistent content moderation policies.

Ultimately, countering CCP propaganda requires a multifaceted approach involving platforms, governments, civil society, and individual users. By understanding the tactics and narratives employed in these campaigns, we can build societal resilience against foreign influence operations while preserving the open exchange of ideas that is essential to democratic discourse.

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